

Neighbours **NEPAL**

But the honeymoon ended, diplomatic sources say, soon after Prachanda took over in August 2008. He immediately snubbed India by announcing his first foreign trip to China. When India sent its envoy to mediate, the hardliners within the Maoists, led by Badal, forced Prachanda to go ahead with the visit. It was the first time a Nepal premier had chosen a foreign destination other than India as his first foreign port of call.

Even a visit by Prachanda to New Delhi in September 2008 failed to bridge the growing mistrust and no serious attempt was made to improve ties. Using the opportunity, the Chinese quietly began a process of increasing cultural influence and discussing a new friendship treaty with Nepal with a view to gaining a strategic foothold in a country which is a buffer between India and China. Even though Prachanda did deliver on some of his assurances of addressing India's security concerns by handing over some key terror suspects, the big issues of an extradition treaty and a mutual legal assistance treaty pushed by India were put on the backburner. In contrast, Beijing was forging defence deals and friendship visits and was angling for key hydropower con-

tracts, obviously aimed at sidelining India. Now, the latest crisis has added a new dimension of uncertainty. On May 5, the all-party meeting convened at the behest of the National Congress with the CPN-UML at the forefront to resolve the crisis saw 22 of the 24 coalition parties attending it. Conspicuous by their absence were the Maoists, though they had been invited. "We will invite the Maoists again because we want the National Unity Government to come into place at the earliest," says Ishwar Pokhriyal, CPN-UML leader.

It is now a numbers game with the magic figure being 301. Standing in the way of the UML forming a government with the help of the NC is the fact that together they add up to 223. The interim constitution of Nepal gives the first option of forming a government to whoever is the most acceptable candidate for all members of the Constituent Assembly. The most likely scenario emerging out of this is the UML-NC combine with senior leader Madhav Nepal at the helm of affairs. "The next prime minister has to be a man who is acceptable to all parties," says Nepal. The next option is given to the single largest party, in this case the Maoists with 238

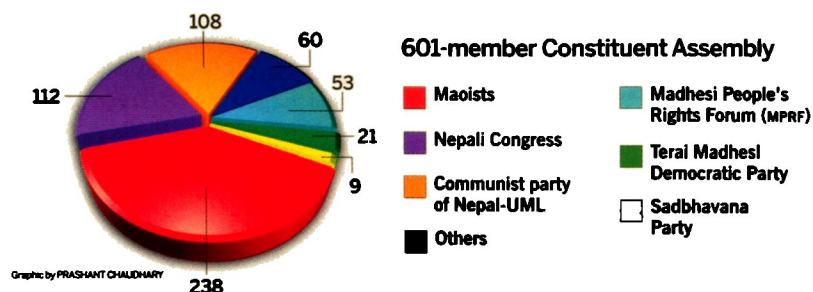


AFP

lawmakers. But there is also a third scenario that may emerge. Upendra Yadav, the present foreign minister who heads one of the key coalition partners in Prachanda's government, is a former Maoist who is now a leader of the Madhesi. His party has 53 lawmakers. But there is a possibility that owing to his old friendship with the Maoists, they may prop him up as their prime ministerial candidate and continue to run the government through him. While the political ping-pong continues, for the average Nepali it is the

Scenarios

Maoists will continue to play a crucial role in the power game



Scenario 1

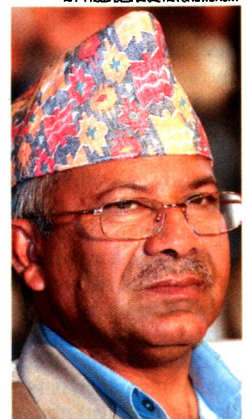
A national unity government led by Communist Party of Nepal leader Madhav Nepal is formed with Nepali Congress and the Madhesi parties supporting them.

Scenario 2

Maoists sabotage efforts of government formation and continue the agitation as well as keep blocking the Constituent Assembly sittings. They may force an early election to try and win a majority.

Scenario 3

Maoists support foreign minister Upendra Yadav for the prime minister's job. The former Maoists of MPRF have 53 members. Maoists may extend support from outside and run the government through proxy.



MADHAV NEPAL: TIPPED TO BECOME THE NEW PREMIER